

Obituary

A. P. PENDLETON.

A. P. Pendleton, a veteran travelling salesman for Solon Palmer, the well-known manufacturing perfumer, died at his home in Chicago on March 9th after a protracted illness.

Mr. Pendleton was associated with Solon Palmer for over forty years and in his younger days travelled for Palmer's specialties over the greater part of the United States. Of late years, however, he devoted his entire time to the Chicago district. He was well known and liked, and the news of his death will bring a feeling of genuine regret to a wide circle of friends and acquaintances in the drug trade.

George Pfromm.

George Pfromm, father of Adam Pfromm, of A. Pfromm & Co., wholesale druggists, Philadelphia, Pa., died recently at the home of his son, Dr. George E. Pfromm, in Philadelphia. He was a native of Germany, where he was born in 1828. He came to America in 1856 and retired from business in 1905.

George F. Adams.

George F. Adams, a well-known druggist of Southerlin, Oregon, died recently from influenza. A widow and three children survive him.

Frederick C. Newbourg.

Frederick C. Newbourg, actively identified with the wholesale drug trade of Philadelphia, died recently at his home in that city, aged seventy-eight years.

William Eppinger.

William Eppinger, manager of the Wakelee Drug Store, San Francisco, Cal., died recently. Interment was at Hollister, Cal.

GERMANY LOSING RARE EARTH TRADE.

How greatly the United States is attaining its chemical independence was pointed out by Dr. Harlan S. Miner, chairman of the Philadelphia, Pa., section of the American Chemical Society in an address on the subject, "The Rare Earths."

This well-known chemist has done important pioneer work in putting to practical uses many rare minerals for the supply of which, before the World War, the United States was almost wholly dependent upon Germany and Austria.

The need for certain chemicals used in the practical arts was developed very strongly when the supply of them was cut off shortly after the war began in 1914. In the sale of some of these minerals, Germany practically held a monopoly. With the development of the southern states, it has been found that land which is of small value for agriculture was rich in rare earths, the presence of which has been scarcely suspected.

Dr. Miner spoke especially of the production and the practical use of such minerals as thorium, mesothorium and cerium, the principal commercial value of which is for the making of gas mantels. Although the rare earths from which they are derived come principally from India and from Brazil, the Germans were able to get substantial control of the handling of these elements. They imported the raw material, put it through the commercial processes and reshipped it back to the Western Hemisphere. Dr. Miner spoke of the tremendous advances which have been made by American industrial chemistry in the last year or so, through which it was possible for these rare earths to be processed in the United States and thereby considerable expense saved.

He also announced that considerable progress has been made in the turning out in commercial quantities of mesothorium, which is an intensely radio-active substance. It is chemically identical with radium and may be used for many of the same purposes. As the demand for radium in the treatment of diseases, especially of cancer, increases, the importance of having radio-active bodies becomes more pronounced.

In North Carolina and in other southern states, deposits of these rare earths have been disclosed, and it is believed that eventually they will not only be a source of chemical independence to the United States, but that their mining will add considerably to the wealth of the regions in which they are found.

Boards of Pharmacy

Pennsylvania.

The Pennsylvania Board of Pharmacy has announced results of the examinations conducted on March 5 and 6, showing that of 105 applicants there were twenty-five taking examinations for registered pharmacists and eighty for assistants. Fourteen of the former and forty-two of the latter passed.

The next examinations will be held in Philadelphia and Pittsburgh June 4 and 5. For application blanks and particulars write Secretary L. L. Walton, P. O. Box 265, Williamsport, Pa.

North Carolina.

The next meeting of the North Carolina Board of Pharmacy for the examination of candidates for license to practice pharmacy will be held in Raleigh, on Tuesday, June 8, 1920, at 9 A. M.

F. W. HANCOCK, Secretary.

NEW COAL TAR PROCESS.

Announcement has recently been made that by a newly discovered method, coal tar can be made to yield tartaric acid and other important substances which will help to lower the cost of living. The details were explained in a joint paper read before the New York Section of the American Chemical Society, written by the inventors and patentees of the process, John M. Weiss and C. R. Downs, respectively the manager and the chief chemist of a well-known firm of chemical manufacturers.

The basis of the process is a method of building up various substances from maleic acid obtained from benzol, one of the derivatives of dark and viscid acid coal tar. Maleic acid has been separated from the juices of certain plants and fruits, but at so high a cost that it could not be put on the market and was considered merely as a laboratory curiosity. By the Weiss-Downs process benzol is mixed with air and the vapor is passed over a catalyzer, a material which alters the speed of chemical reactions without being itself affected. On account of their mysterious power to join other substances in chemical wedlock, catalyzers are known as "chemical parsons."

With maleic acid as a base, it is possible to prepare other valuable acids. Of these, the most welcome to the house-keeper and the trade is tartaric, which hitherto has been made from the cream of tartar, a solid found in the bottom of wine casks and employed principally in the making of baking powder. The United States has produced ten million pounds of cream of tartar a year and about a million pounds of tartaric acid. As the cream of tartar cannot be obtained except through the fermentation of the wine, the grape juice industry, owing to prohibition, is unable to supply the household wants hitherto filled from the vats of the vintner. There was a large importation from Europe before the war, but it was checked by the military situation.

By the new process citric acid can also be derived from the maleic acid base. Citric acid causes the sour taste of lemons and other citric fruits, and is used in lemonade and orange drink compounds. It is much employed also in the arts.

Lactic acid can also be manufactured inexpensively by the new method. It was originally derived by fermenting milk, as its name implies, although there are now several other processes for preparing it synthetically. Recently, farmers have been giving lactic acid as a tonic and appetizer to pigs, for although the porcine breed is supposed always to be hungry, it is found that its craving for food and powers of assimilation, and therefore its weight, could be greatly increased by such a prescription.

Succinic acid, which is useful in making many laboratory tests, can also be derived at a low figure by the newly devised method. As it is obtained by the distillation of amber ordinarily, this substance is costly.

Maleic acid synthesized from benzol, the inventors state, can also be employed as the basis of new dyes, medicinals and perfumes. They believe, in fact, that it will open up an entirely new field of synthetic organic chemistry. Arrangements are being made to manufacture products from this new source on a large scale, as the process would render the United States independent of foreign supplies of several important raw materials. Three American patents have been issued to the authors.

You can save money by using old prescription corks over again as stoppers in perfumery bottles, but all druggists don't practice this economy.